

most out of the pitch. Death bowling is another key area. A lot of our planning goes into how to approach the last five overs.

Sometimes the plans work, sometimes they don't. But when they do, we usually end up on the winning side. That's how it is—cricket is all about probabilities. You can never be 100% sure a plan will work. You just play the odds.

Do you actively work on adding new variations to stay ahead, or is it more about refining your existing skills?

Both. Around 80 percent of my focus goes into refining my existing skills, and 20 percent into developing a new variation.

Over time — say two to three years — that new variation gradually blends into my overall skill set, and I start refining that as well.

That's the process: introduce a variation, then keep refining it. But the work on your core skills never really stops.

How do you ensure that batters don't start reading you easily, given that most 'mystery spinners' eventually get figured out?

In the first two or three years, I used to overthink that a lot. But over time, I realised — even if batters figure you out, they still have to play the ball. There's always a human element, and the pitch will always offer some natural variation. So even if they know what I'm bowling, they still need to get the timing right.

Now, I don't worry about it much. The pitch, the human touch, and the element of surprise — like when I choose to bowl a particular delivery — those are things they can't fully predict. That's what I rely on.

You appear very calm and composed on the pitch, but do you carry your office back home?

I think about the game constantly — 24x7. Whether I'm waking up, in the shower, at the gym — whatever I'm doing, my mind is on the last match and how I can improve.

It can be irritating for people close to me because I'm often lost in my



Standing out: When Varun Chakaravathy had pushed for a Champions Trophy spot despite no ODI caps, Rohit Sharma backed him, saying he'd "clearly brought something different to the table." REUTERS

own world. But that's just who I've become. And honestly, that's what the game demands today.

India captain Rohit Sharma mentioned that you don't use your variations in the nets. What's the thought process behind that?

(Laughs) That's not true. I've already clarified this before. It's not that I don't use all my variations—I do. It's just that I sequence them differently in ODIs compared to T20s.

In T20s, I rely more on certain deliveries, while in ODIs, I use others more often. That's all there is to it.

How do you balance the need to keep your variations secret while still preparing effectively for matches?

I don't think there's anything to keep secret anymore. Everyone knows what I bowl — it's all out there in the media and video analysis.

I rely more on the natural variation from the pitch and my own decision-making — knowing what to bowl and when.

So no, I don't focus on being secretive now.

You started late and didn't come through the age-group or domestic system. Without that base to fall back on, how did you manage to bounce back so quickly after setbacks?

I didn't play age-group cricket at all — I started playing seriously only at 26. But since then, I've played a lot of domestic matches. The last two Vijay Hazare seasons, in particular, helped me prepare for the Champions Trophy. Whenever I'm not playing international cricket, I'm playing domestic games. I believe the quality of domestic cricket in India is very high. Some domestic sides could beat international teams on their day. You have to stay sharp — there's no room to take it lightly. For me, that's the real preparation ground.

Any specific aspects that you have learned from your domestic experiences?

Domestic batters are excellent against spin and can hit you anywhere. What helped me prepare was learning how to outsmart them and stay ahead. If you can dominate